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THE

ARCHITECTURE

— OF —

DAYS

A NOVEL OF BECOMING

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— By —

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THE ARCHITECTURE OF DAYS

A Novel of Becoming

*For everyone who has ever stood at the edge of their own life, looked down into the wreckage
of who they were, and wondered if it was too late to begin again.*

It is not.

A NOTE BEFORE WE BEGIN

This is not a This is a story about a man who needed help so desperately that the universe conspired, in its ancient and unhurried way, to give it to him — not in the form of answers, but in the form of people. People who had already walked through fire. People who had found, in the most ordinary of disciplines, the most extraordinary of freedoms. What follows is his journey. And perhaps, if you are honest with yourself, it is yours as well.

Chapter 1

The Morning That Broke Him

The alarm went off at 7:14 AM and Arjun did what he had been doing with the alarm for the better part of eight months: he picked up the phone, looked at it with one eye, felt a brief, formless hostility toward the concept of morning, and silenced it.

He put the phone face-down on the mattress.

He had set the alarm three years ago during a period of his life he now thought of as Before, with a capital B, the way religious people think of time before and after some transformative event, except his wasn't particularly transformative, it was just — a different time. The 7:14 was specific because he'd done the math. Shower at 7:15, seven minutes. Dressed by 7:25, assuming he ironed his shirt the night before, which he usually had. Chai by 7:30. Out the door by 7:48. He used to calculate things like that. He used to iron his shirts the night before. He used to be the kind of person who thought about what version of himself would show up to the next morning.

That person had not left dramatically. He had just — thinned out, gradually, like a photograph left in sunlight, until one day Arjun had looked in the mirror and not been entirely sure who was looking back.

He lay there.

The ceiling above him had a crack that ran from the light fixture toward the window, a thin diagonal fault that had been there since he moved in. He'd reported it to the building manager twice. Nothing had come of it. The crack had become, in the months of ceiling-staring, a kind of companion — familiar in the way that only meaningless things become familiar when you spend enough time with them. He'd started to notice that it looked different depending on the light. At eight in the morning it was almost invisible. By noon, when the sun came around to the west-facing window, it threw a faint shadow that made it look deeper than it was.

He knew these things because he had been in the bed when all of these things happened.

Outside, Mumbai was doing what Mumbai always did: producing noise at a volume that communicated genuine indifference to whether you had anywhere to be. Auto-rickshaws, someone's TV, the vegetable vendor on the street below who announced his wares in a call that was technically words but had evolved, through years of repetition, into something more like a birdcall. *Tamaatarr. Caalii. Tamaatarr.*

Arjun had once loved that sound.

He lay there until his second alarm went off at 8:01. He silenced that one too. Then he lay there until his body made a decision his mind hadn't authorized, and he sat up.

His head did the thing it had started doing in the mornings — a brief, dull complaint, not exactly a headache, more like a headache's ghost. He attributed this to the whiskey and was probably

right. He swung his legs over the side of the bed and sat on the edge with his hands on his knees and looked at the floor.

The floor had a sock on it that had been there for four days. He was aware of this. He had not done anything about it.

He stood up. His knees cracked, which was new and annoying — he was thirty-two, his knees had no business cracking yet. He shuffled to the window and looked down at the street.

Below: the usual. The chai wallah whose stall had been on that corner longer than anyone could remember, currently arguing with a customer about something. Three school children in uniforms, one of whom had his shirt untucked and seemed aggressively unbothered by this. Two dogs conducting negotiations over a piece of something unidentifiable. And an old man doing his morning walk — the slow, deliberate kind that old men do, hands clasped behind his back, moving at a pace that suggested he had somewhere to be but had also made peace with the possibility that he might not get there.

The old man stopped almost directly below Arjun's window. Looked down at something on the pavement. A coin, maybe, or just a crack in the concrete. Then he looked up.

He looked directly at Arjun.

Arjun didn't move. There was a particular awkwardness to being seen by a stranger when you were standing at your window at — he checked his phone — 9:23 in the morning, unshaven, in a faded t-shirt that said something about a music festival in 2019. The old man's expression didn't convey judgment exactly. It didn't convey much of anything. He simply looked, with the unhurried quality of someone who had decided long ago that the world would go on regardless of how long he looked at things, and then he nodded — just once, a small inclination of the head — and continued his walk.

Arjun watched him go.

He stood at the window for longer than he'd stood anywhere in weeks. He wasn't sure why. The old man rounded the corner and disappeared and the street returned to its ordinary business and Arjun stood there in his four-day-old t-shirt and thought about nothing in particular, which was different from the nothing-in-particular he usually thought about, because usually the nothing had a quality of heaviness, of things-avoided, and this nothing was just — quiet.

He went to the kitchen. The sink had two cups and a plate in it. The counter had a newspaper he'd bought three days ago and not read. He filled the kettle and turned it on and stood there waiting for it, which was something he hadn't done in — he couldn't remember how long. Usually he turned the kettle on and then went to look at his phone or opened his laptop and the kettle boiled unwitnessed. But he stood there this time, for no reason he could articulate, and watched the small light on the base.

He made chai.

He wasn't thinking about his grandmother's recipe. He wasn't thinking about anything very much. He put teabags in because he couldn't find the loose tea — or maybe he'd run out, he couldn't remember buying any — and he added too much sugar because he wasn't measuring and he drank it standing at the counter looking at the unread newspaper.

It was too sweet. Also somehow too watery and too strong at the same time. He drank it anyway.

His phone buzzed. He turned it over.

Rajan: *yaar the Henderson team is asking for you again. told them you'd left. they said they knew. they want you anyway. call me when you surface from wherever you are*

Arjun read it twice. He put the phone back down, screen-up this time, and looked at the newspaper headline about a state election he had no feelings about.

Henderson, he thought. He had designed their entire data architecture three years ago, a project that had taken him five months and that he was, if he was honest, still proud of. The team there had sent him a bottle of whiskey when it launched. He hadn't thought about that project in eight months. He hadn't thought about anything that required sustained thought in eight months.

He looked at the newspaper for another minute. He didn't read it.

He went back to bed.

But he lay there differently this time. He lay there and looked at the ceiling crack and thought: *something has to change*. Which he had thought before, many times, but always with a kind of exhausted futility attached to it, like a man wishing for rain from inside a drought. This time the thought arrived without the exhaustion. Just the thought by itself, clean and flat, like a fact.

Something has to change.

He picked up his phone and called Rajan.

"Oh good, you're alive," Rajan said. "I was giving it another week and then I was going to show up."

"You wouldn't have."

"I absolutely would have. My wife was already planning what to bring. She made a shortlist of your favorite foods. It was a kind of wellness intervention in casserole form."

Arjun almost smiled. "Tell her that's not necessary."

"She'll be disappointed. She enjoys a project." A pause. "How are you actually?"

"I don't know," Arjun said, which was more honest than what he usually said, which was *fine* or *managing* or some other word that meant nothing. "I think — not great. I think I need to do something. I don't know what."

"Okay," Rajan said. He didn't push. He waited.

"Can you come over? This week sometime?"

"Tonight," Rajan said. "I'll come tonight. Have you eaten today?"

"I had chai."

"That's not — never mind. I'll bring food. Don't do anything dramatic before seven PM."

"I'm not going to do anything dramatic."

"I know. I'm being annoying because I care about you. See you at seven."

Chapter 2

Rajan's Question

Rajan arrived at 7:22, which was very Rajan — nominally late but holding a bag that contained, as far as Arjun could tell, approximately three meals' worth of food from the restaurant down the road plus a six-pack of beer.

He stood in the doorway of Arjun's apartment and did the thing where he looked around the room without commenting on what he saw, which was considerate of him because what he saw was — not ideal. The newspaper still on the counter. The sock still on the floor. A topography of empty glasses and stacked books and the general entropy of a space that had been inhabited by someone not particularly interested in inhabiting it.

"Nice place," Rajan said.

"Don't."

"I mean it. Minimalist. Very of-the-moment."

"Rajan."

"Right." He put the bag down on the counter. "Sit. Eat. We can have the real conversation after."

So they sat on the small balcony with containers of dal and rice and some kind of chicken thing that Rajan had ordered specifically because he knew Arjun liked it, which was the sort of thing Rajan did without making a production of it. The October evening was doing its tentative thing — Mumbai's version of cool, which meant it was maybe twenty-four degrees instead of thirty, but the slight drop was real and the air felt less like something you had to push through.

They ate.

Rajan talked about his work for a while — he was a project manager at a mid-sized tech firm, perpetually involved in what he called "completely preventable disasters of human coordination." He described a particular disaster from the previous week involving a deadline and two teams that had apparently been sending emails to each other for six weeks without anyone actually reading the responses. It was a good story. Arjun found himself listening, actually listening, which felt different from the half-listening he'd been doing for months, where he registered that a person was speaking without anything they said landing.

"—and then Mehta from the backend team, not you obviously, different Mehta, produces this spreadsheet that he'd been maintaining in secret for the entire project, which had all the actual timelines on it, which were completely different from the timelines everyone else thought they were working toward, and I just—" Rajan made a gesture of cosmic resignation. "I looked at him and I genuinely did not know whether to fire him or make him employee of the month."

"What did you do?"

"I went home and didn't think about it until Monday. Which is basically what you should do with ninety percent of workplace crises." He picked up his beer. "Speaking of which."

"We weren't speaking of it."

"We were approaching it." Rajan leaned back. "Tell me things."

Arjun looked at the street below. Someone had set up a small stall directly below the balcony — he hadn't noticed it appearing, but there it was, a man selling something bright-colored in small bags, already doing reasonable business.

"I don't know where to start," Arjun said.

"Start wherever. I'm not going anywhere."

"It's going to sound—" He stopped.

"What?"

"It's going to sound very self-pitying and also not particularly interesting."

"Most honest things sound self-pitying at first," Rajan said. "That's not a reason not to say them. And also, Arjun, I've known you for twelve years. You can be uninteresting with me."

So Arjun talked. Not in any organized way — he circled around things, went back, corrected himself, started sentences and didn't finish them and started different ones. He talked about the feeling of watching his own life from a distance. He talked about the whiskey, not defensively but matter-of-factly, because it was a fact. He talked about Priya — not about the marriage ending specifically but about the months before, the particular texture of those months, the way he'd been physically present in their apartment while being almost entirely elsewhere, absorbed in the work that was itself becoming increasingly unreal, until the work failed and took the absorbing with it and left him with — nothing in particular, to be in the presence of.

Rajan listened. He was good at this. He ate, occasionally, and refilled his beer, but he didn't do the thing some people do where they're visibly waiting for their turn to speak. He just listened.

When Arjun ran out of things to say there was a pause that wasn't uncomfortable.

"Okay," Rajan said.

"Okay what?"

"Okay, I heard all of that." He put his bottle down. "Can I say something that might come across as annoying?"

"You're going to anyway."

"True, but I'm doing you the courtesy of a warning." He picked at the label on his beer bottle. "You described everything that's been happening to you from the outside. The startup, Priya, moving here. Very clear picture. What you didn't describe — what I noticed you didn't describe — is anything

about what a regular day actually looks like for you now. Like the texture of it. What time you get up. What you do with yourself."

"I described that to you."

"You said you don't do much. That's not the same thing." He paused. "Walk me through it. Actually walk me through it. What happened today. From when you woke up."

Arjun looked at him. "Is this going to be one of your managerial frameworks."

"I don't have a framework. I'm just asking."

"It's going to turn into a framework."

"Maybe. But first tell me."

Arjun sighed. "I woke up. Eventually. I made chai. I called you."

"What time did you wake up?"

"Does it matter?"

"Humor me."

"Around nine."

Rajan nodded, no reaction.

"Before the phone call you were at the window," Rajan said. "You told me you were at the window."

"I was at the window."

"And before that you were in bed."

"Rajan, you're doing a very dramatic reconstruction of my extremely boring morning."

"I know. Keep going. Before bed — what happened last night?"

"I watched things. Ate something. Read a bit." He thought about it. "Had a drink or two."

"And before that?"

"I don't know. It was yesterday."

Rajan was quiet for a moment. He looked out at the city. Then he said, in a different tone — not the slightly performative curious tone but something more straight: "I want to ask you something and you don't have to answer. When things were — better. Before all of this. What did your days actually look like? Like actually look like. The structure of them."

Arjun considered this. It was a strange question to find difficult — it was just his old life, he should be able to describe it. But the specifics kept slipping.

"I got up early," he said. "Five-thirty, six. I used to run." He paused. "I made chai in the morning. Proper chai, my grandmother's thing — cardamom before the tea leaves, specific order. She was very firm about that." He almost smiled. "She explained the reasoning to me once and I've completely forgotten it but I still do it that way."

"Did," Rajan said gently.

"Did." He shifted. "I had this notebook. I wrote in it in the mornings. Nothing organized — just whatever. Then work. Then evenings I cooked, usually, or sometimes Priya did. We watched things together. I read before bed." He was quiet for a moment. "Dostoevsky. I was in the middle of *Brothers Karamazov* when everything — I stopped reading it. I still have the book. It's in a box under the bed."

Rajan was quiet.

"What?" Arjun said.

"Nothing."

"You have a face."

"I always have a face. It's my face." He picked up his beer. "I'm just noticing the difference between the two descriptions you just gave me. The second one and the first one. The recent one is — very general. Things. Something. Watched, ate, drank. The older one has — cardamom before the tea leaves, five-thirty, *Brothers Karamazov*. It's all specific."

Arjun looked at him.

"I don't know what conclusion you're building toward," Arjun said. "And I can tell you're building toward one."

"I'm not. I'm genuinely just saying what I noticed." He paused. "Though I will say — and this is not a framework, it's just an observation from being someone who has known you for twelve years — when I picture you in the cardamom-before-the-tea-leaves period, I can picture you. I have a clear picture. When I picture you now, I — don't, quite. You're sort of blurry."

"That's a very poetic way to tell someone they've let themselves go."

"I didn't say that. I said blurry. It's different."

"How."

Rajan considered this for a moment. "Letting yourself go implies you've gotten worse. Blurry implies you've gotten — less defined. Less specific. You could become more specific again. Worse is harder to come back from." He shrugged. "Probably I'm overcomplicating it. I usually do."

They sat for a while without talking. Below, the stall-man had packed up and moved further down the street, following some logic of customer traffic that was invisible from above.

"There's someone I want you to meet," Rajan said. "Old man. He was my father's friend. He lives in Pune, which I know is not ideal, but." He paused. "He's—" He seemed to be deciding how to describe him. "He's not a therapist or anything like that. He just — he gardens. He's been gardening in the same garden every morning for like forty years. He's sort of famously difficult. My father loved him."

"You want me to go visit an elderly gardener in Pune," Arjun said.

"I want to give you his number and let you decide what to do with it."

"What would I even say to him?"

"I don't know. Whatever." Rajan scratched the back of his neck. "Look, I'm not saying it's going to fix anything. I'm saying he's a real person who has done something I think you might find — I don't know. Interesting. Maybe useful. Maybe not." He looked at Arjun. "You said something has to change."

"I said that to you this morning."

"You also mean it in a way you haven't meant things in a while. I can tell."

Arjun looked at the city. The lights below doing their usual work of making the whole enormous mess look, from a distance, almost organized.

"Text me his number," Arjun said.

Chapter 3

The Decision

He didn't do anything with the number for five days.

He put it in his phone under the name *Krishnamurthy - Rajan's person* and then went about the business of not deciding things, which he had become extremely good at. He ate. He slept and then lay awake and then slept again. He watched several episodes of a series he was only half interested in and then switched to a different series and was only half interested in that one too.

On the third day he opened Krishnamurthy's contact and typed and deleted three different messages.

Hello, Rajan gave me your number—

That felt like an opening to a conversation he didn't know how to have.

Hi, I'm a friend of Rajan Iyer's—

A lie, essentially. He wasn't Rajan's friend exactly, he was Rajan's person-in-crisis, which was different.

I don't know why I'm texting but Rajan—

He deleted that one the fastest.

He closed the contact and made himself another chai. He'd been making chai more often this week. Not consciously — it wasn't a resolution or a practice — he just kept finding himself standing at the stove when he was bored or restless, and the thing to do at the stove was to make chai. He had found the loose tea eventually, behind the Nescafe, and the chai had gotten better. He'd remembered about the cardamom while reaching for the sugar.

On the fourth day he called his mother.

He hadn't planned this either. He was looking for something on his phone and scrolled past her name and then he was dialing.

She answered on the second ring.

"Arjun." Just his name. The way she said it had more information in it than most people put in whole sentences.

"Aai."

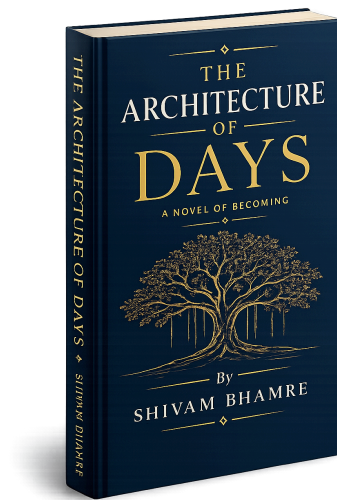
He was not going to cry. He was absolutely not going to cry, he was thirty-two years old. He was not going to—

"Tell me what's happening," his mother said.

It turned out he was going to cry, a little bit, at least to start with. The kind of crying that happens because you've been alone in your own head for too long and then someone who has known you your whole life says your name in a particular way. It passed quickly. He was mildly mortified about it and she waited it out without comment.

Enjoyed this sample?

Arjun's journey has only just begun.



Discover the lessons, friendships, and transformations that
await in the chapters ahead.

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